Shahriar Shayesteh

Ph.D. Candidate in Informatics, Pennsylvania State University, USA
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Research Focus

My research focuses on two complementary areas: **agentic AI privacy**—how LLMs, tools, and context shape privacy risks when agentic systems act on users' behalf—and **NLP for consumer-oriented legal documents**—how language technologies can help consumers navigate contracts and policies, and the failure modes that can limit their usefulness.

Education

Pennsylvania State University Aug 2023 – Spring 2028 (Expected)
Ph.D. in Informatics, College of Information Sciences and Technology.
Advisor: Prof. Shomir Wilson GPA: 3.93/4.0

University of Ottawa Sep 2020 – Jun 2023
M.Sc. in Computer Science. Supervisor: Prof. Diana Inkpen GPA: 4.0/4.0

University of British Columbia Sep 2017 – May 2020
Non-degree coursework in Computer Science and Statistics GPA: 3.73/4.0

Ferdowsi University of Mashhad 2010 – 2015
B.Sc. in Electrical Engineering (Telecommunications)

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Publications and Poster

[1] From Conventional Web Privacy to Agentic Disclosure: How Tool Schemas May Invite LLM Oversharing
Shahriar Shayesteh, Shomir Wilson
7th Workshop on Privacy in Natural Language Processing (PrivateNLP @ ACL), 2026

[2] SoAC and SoACer: A Sector-Based Corpus and LLM-Based Framework for Sectoral Website Classification
Shahriar Shayesteh, Mukund Srinath, Lee Matheson, Lu Xian, Sinjoy Saha, C. Lee Giles, Shomir Wilson
ACM Symposium on Document Engineering (DocEng), 2025

[3] The PrivaSeer Project: Large-Scale Resources for Analysis of Privacy Policy Text
Shomir Wilson, Florian Schaub, Lee Matheson, Shahriar Shayesteh, Lu Xian
USENIX Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS), Poster, 2025

[4] Generative Adversarial Learning with Negative Data Augmentation for Semi-Supervised Text Classification
Shahriar Shayesteh, Diana Inkpen
International FLAIRS Conference (FLAIRS-35), 2022

Manuscript Under Revision (Not Yet Published)

- **Privacy, More or Less: A Large-Scale Comparison of Privacy-Policy Disclosure Patterns Across Online Sectors**
  Shahriar Shayesteh, Lu Xian, Shomir Wilson
  Under revision for Proceedings on Privacy Enhancing Technologies (PoPETs), 2027

Manuscripts in Preparation (Not Yet Submitted)

- **How Tool Schemas Shape LLM Agent Disclosure: Structure and Guidance**
  Shahriar Shayesteh, Shomir Wilson
  In preparation
- **Easier to Read, Still Easy to Miss: Accessibility and Protective Salience in LLM Contract Explanations**
  Shahriar Shayesteh, Shomir Wilson
  In preparation; targeting ACM FAccT 2027

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant Aug 2023 – Present
Human Language Technologies Lab, Pennsylvania State University

- **Agentic privacy:** Audited 2,344 third-party tool schemas to characterize interface conditions that may invite unnecessary personal-information disclosure by tool-using LLMs; published at PrivateNLP @ ACL 2026.
- Designing controlled experiments that hold the user task and backend behavior fixed while varying tool-schema structure and natural-language guidance, measuring unnecessary disclosure in agent tool-call arguments.
- **Consumer legal documents:** Developing a source-grounded evaluation of LLM-generated wireless contract explanations across 24 topics, measuring topic coverage, omission, preservation of contractual conditions, and factual support.
- Analyzed 59,590 matched 2022–2025 privacy-policy pairs to study changes in disclosure patterns across online sectors; conducted preliminary manual validation of the extraction pipeline.
- Contributed to PrivaSeer's 3,967,487-policy corpus and SoAC's 195,495-website sector corpus.

Graduate Research Assistant Jan 2021 – Jun 2023
NLP Laboratory, University of Ottawa

- Developed NDA-GAN, a semi-supervised text-classification model using negative data augmentation; improved classification accuracy and out-of-distribution detection relative to GAN-BERT (FLAIRS 2022; M.Sc. thesis).

Research Intern Feb 2022 – Apr 2022
Department of Canadian Heritage, Government of Canada

- Applied topic modeling and sentiment analysis to qualitative data on challenges faced by Canadian artists; translated model outputs into findings for government policy analysts.

Research Training Participant Jun 2023
Responsible AI and Human Rights Summer School, Mila

- Participated in interdisciplinary training on responsible AI and human rights.

Teaching Experience

University of Ottawa	Teaching Assistant
CSI 5389: Electronic Commerce Technologies	Winter 2023
ITI 1121: Introduction to Computing II	Fall 2022
ITI 1121: Introduction to Computing II	Winter 2022
ITI 1120: Introduction to Computing I	Fall 2021
University of British Columbia	Teaching Assistant
CPSC 340: Machine Learning and Data Mining	Summer 2021
CPSC 440/540: Advanced Machine Learning	Winter 2021
CPSC 340: Machine Learning and Data Mining (**Head TA**)	Fall 2020
CPSC 340: Machine Learning and Data Mining	Summer 2020
CPSC 340: Machine Learning and Data Mining	Fall 2019

Talks and Academic Service

Invited Guest Lecture (scheduled), IST 574: Human Language Technologies, Penn State	Oct 2026
Presenter, PrivateNLP Workshop @ ACL	Jul 2026
Reviewer, 5th Workshop on Trustworthy NLP (TrustNLP @ NAACL)	Feb 2025
Panelist, IST 197: Introduction to Research in IST, Penn State	Mar 2025

Technical Skills

Programming: Python, SQL, Java, C++
ML and NLP: PyTorch, TensorFlow, Hugging Face, scikit-learn, pandas, NumPy
LLMs and Agents: LLM evaluation, tool calling, agentic workflows, Model Context Protocol (MCP), hosted and self-hosted inference
Research Methods: Experimental design, annotation protocols, inter-annotator agreement, non-parametric testing

References

Prof. Shomir Wilson
Associate Professor, College of Information Sciences and Technology, Pennsylvania State University
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